



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: American Preparatory Academy: Draper 1

School Website: <https://draper1.americanprep.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

American Preparatory Academy Draper 1 (APA Draper 1) demonstrates a clearly classical-inflected orientation, with strong emphasis on a liberal-arts framework, mastery of fundamentals, and character formation. The campus materials consistently describe a classical education model (Trivium: grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a curriculum anchored in core knowledge with attention to virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing. Evidence also shows practices aligned with the Great Conversation and a rhetoric of public-speaking and intellectual discipline. However, the materials do not reveal explicit theological or liturgical foundations (i.e., Grounded in Theology or Liturgical/Communal practices) in the public-facing materials, and the pedagogy includes notable use of Direct Instruction in elementary grades alongside Socratic and rhetoric-based activities in upper grades. Taken together, APA Draper 1 sits squarely in the Classical spectrum, but with notable caveats that keep it from a wholesale “CLASSICAL” label across all six categories.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Key insights: - Strengths in: Trivium-centered curriculum, Core Knowledge alignment, emphasis on virtue and human flourishing, presence of Great Conversation themes, and clearly stated mission to develop virtuous, capable citizens through a classical liberal arts approach. Citations: Our Philosophy and Mission statements; Trivium emphasis; Core Knowledge/Shurley/Saxon usage; Great Conversation initiatives. - Areas to strengthen for deeper classical alignment: explicit theology/liturgical/community practices; consistently project-based or seminar-based pedagogy across more grade levels; and a more explicit emphasis on reading Great Books as a central program component. Evidence for current mix includes Direct Instruction in early years alongside Socratic rhetoric in upper years.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize virtue and human flourishing as core aims of classical education, and they present truth, beauty, goodness as themes in student discourse. Examples include statements tying the education to character formation and the pursuit of truth, beauty, goodness and wisdom in “big ideas.” - The materials describe virtue and moral formation as central to the program, with explicit reference to character development and the classical aims of education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; wisdom; human flourishing. Also phrases like “classical education,” “virtuous character development.” - Negative keywords: not overtly present in the public materials (e.g., no explicit relativism, secular-humanist framing, or doctrinally neutral stance identified). The explicit theological-liturgical anchors are not evident in the public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The school foregrounds virtue and the true/beautiful/good as real ideals and centers character formation, which aligns with transcendental moral realism and a non-secular orientation in practice. However, explicit Grounded-in-Theology or liturgical/community-practice signals are not evident in the accessible public materials, which tempers a full Classical label in this category. The presence of virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing indicates strong alignment, but the lack of explicit theological/liturgical signals yields a middle position.

What would move the needle - Public articulation of theological or liturgical dimensions (even if presented as a framework for reverence or the sacred) to demonstrate grounded metaphysical foundations. - Explicit connections between virtue formation and liturgical or communal practices (e.g., morning prayer, chapel, or ritual commemoration) in public materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission is to provide a classical, liberal-arts education oriented toward forming virtuous citizens and preparing students for advanced study, emphasizing human flourishing and wisdom rather than mere job-readiness. - The philosophy is framed around human flourishing as the goal of classical education, with emphasis on virtue, character, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty. - The program emphasizes formation over mere information, mastery of fundamentals, and a long-term aim toward human excellence and moral imagination.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; human flourishing; wisdom; liberal education; telos; scholé; great conversation; classical mission; pursuit of the true, good, beautiful. - Negative keywords: minimal (no strong counter-narrative around “workforce preparation” within the public-facing core statements; some later blog content discusses skills but not as a negation of formation).

Why this rating - The school’s stated purpose centers on formation, virtue, and wisdom within a liberal-arts framework consistent with classical aims. The explicit emphasis on human flourishing and the true/-good/beautiful signals a strong alignment with classical purposes. The presence of claims about formation over information strengthens this category.

What would move the needle - More explicit articulation of a distinctly classical telos in public materials, linking virtue and wisdom directly to daily curriculum choices. - Clarify in public materials how the school’s curriculum consistently supports “formation over information” across all grades (K–12).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum emphasizes the liberal arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and explicitly references the Trivium; the program includes a focus on the classical structure. - The school asserts use of Core Knowledge as a base, paired with Saxon Math and Shurley Grammar, indicating a structured, knowledge-rich approach. - Public materials show history, Western civilization, and classical content being emphasized, with a strong emphasis on language arts and foundational knowledge. - High school offerings include AP and concurrent enrollment, with a continued emphasis on art, music, and the broader liberal-arts program.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; trivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; great books; classics; Western civilization; history; Latin; Greek; primary sources; dialog/narration; music/theology; hymnody (where referenced); Core Knowledge; direct instruction noted but not as the sole method. - Negative keywords: some project-based or experiential constructs appear in other documents, but explicit project-based dominance is not the core of the Draper materials; a notable negative signal is the presence of Direct Instruction in elementary settings, which is contrary to some classical pedagogy expectations.

Why this rating - There is a clear Trivium-based curricular structure and explicit classical-content strands (grammar/logics/rhetoric; core knowledge; Western civilization; Latin/Greek). These align strongly with classical curriculum expectations. The presence of high-school advanced coursework (AP) alongside a classical base supports CLASSICAL labeling for Curriculum, albeit with caveats around the balance with DI in earlier grades.

What would move the needle - Increase explicit public emphasis on Great Books and Great Conversation as central curricular pillars (rather than occasional references) across more grades. - Provide clearer articulation of a unified Great Books/Great Conversation initiative and ensure its explicit integration into daily lessons, reading lists, and assessments.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - There is explicit mention of Socratic discussion and seminars in upper grades, with students trained in rhetoric and opportunities to give speeches. This aligns with classical pedagogical methods in higher grades. - The lower grades reportedly use singing, chanting, and memory-enhancing repetition, which maps to Laus or scholé-style pedagogy (containing elements of contemplative, restorative practice and memory work). - Direct Instruction is used in elementary grades for some subjects (e.g., reading, math). This is a hallmark of a more instrumental approach rather than a purely classical pedagogy and represents a tension within the model. - The school discusses deliberate emphasis on “Power Minds,” data-tracking, and achievement trackers, which reflects a modern, structured performance framework rather than a purely dialogic/classical approach.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminars, rhetoric, public speaking, memory work, recitation, chanting, scholé, contemplation, wonder, seminar, Paideia-style elements. - Negative keywords present: Direct Instruction; project-based learning (documented as a potential negative signal in classical lexica); experiential learning emphasis; constructivist tendencies not clearly evident as core to the model. Presence of Direct Instruction is a notable counterpoint.

Why this rating - The presence of Socratic/seminar-based practices and rhetoric training in upper grades is strongly classical. However, elementary-grade Direct Instruction and other modern performance-tracking methods introduce non-classical pedagogical elements. The overall mix yields a nuanced stance: substantial classical pedagogy in upper grades, but some non-classical practices in other levels. Hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Expand Socratic discussion, seminars, and rhetoric-focused activities more uniformly across all grade levels (K–12) with explicit rubrics, readings, and assessment anchored in classical methods. - Reduce reliance on Direct Instruction in the early grades in favor of language-based, memory-rich, and dialogic pedagogy that aligns with scholé and contemplation.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials emphasize a teacher-as-mentor/guide and a living curriculum approach with a focus on character and virtuous teaching. Public statements discuss teachers modeling virtue and guiding students, and there is emphasis on the faculty’s role in delivering a classical education. - There are references to the “Ambassador program” and other programmatic elements that imply a community-of-practice and a collegiate culture among faculty and students. - The materials discuss a mission-driven faculty, with leadership and governance structures, plus public statements about teacher collaboration and coaching to drive student outcomes. While these are positive indicators, detailed, explicit statements about a formal “portrait of what a teacher should be” or a fully articulated “living curriculum” profile are less explicit in the public facing materials.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; model teachers/mentors; teachers as core of the school; portrait of teacher; collegial culture; great-books seminars for faculty (referenced in lexicon-like materials and school communications). - Negative keywords present: explicit avoidance of non-classical descriptors like “facilitators on the side” or “career-certification jargon” appears in the lexicon, but the public materials do not consistently foreground such negative signals; the absence of a highly formalized “teacher portrait” in the public site is a minor gap.

Why this rating - The school emphasizes virtue-minded teaching and a living-curriculum ethos; there is evidence of teacher mentorship and collaborative professional practice. However, the public materials do not consistently present a fully explicit, codified faculty portrait or formalized classical pedagogy-specific faculty framework to the degree sometimes described in classical schools. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Publish a formal, public-facing “Portrait of a Classical Teacher” and a concise “Living Curriculum” description that codifies expectations, professional development, and the teacher as living exemplar of the classical tradition. - Highlight faculty seminars or seminars-on-seminars for teachers to model the Great Conversation and classical pedagogy in practice.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnerships with families and considers parents as co-educators. Public materials describe parental involvement mechanisms, events, and formation opportunities (e.g., parent meetings, family participation, and ambassador programming). The school indicates a willingness to welcome parents into the culture and to engage them in the classical formation of students. - There are references to parent formation opportunities (e.g., book clubs, gatherings) and programs to educate parents about classical education; the school stresses open campus and opportunities to visit. This demonstrates a public-facing commitment to parent partnership and involvement. - The school's materials mention events and family engagement as a continuous dimension of school life, including assemblies that recite American ideals and engage families in the "Great Conversation" framing.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parent formation; reading groups; seminars; classical book clubs; open campus; family participation; parent covenants. - Negative keywords present: consumer language signals and minimal parental involvement would be flagged as negative in some classical lexicons, but the APA materials emphasize active parental involvement. The detectable public material does not push a consumer-only stance; it leans toward active partnership.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a robust, public-facing commitment to parental involvement and community formation consistent with classical education norms, including co-education and family formation activities. The evidence supports CLASSICAL in this category.

What would move the needle - Continue to expand and publicize formal parent-education programs (e.g., classical education book studies, parent gatherings) and explicitly document outcomes and alignment with the Great Conversation, to strengthen the public understanding of parents as co-educators.

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Introduce and publicize a formal, stated metaphysical framework (theology, liturgy, or sacred-taste structure) that aligns with classical, transcendent real-forms and the Great Conversation, making explicit how reverence, wonder, and awe guide everyday learning.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Expand Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy across more grades, reduce elementary DI usage, and publish a curriculum map that shows stepwise progression from memory/chant/restful study to Socratic inquiry and rhetorical exercises.
- For Element 5 (Faculty): Publish a public-facing portrait of the teacher and a concise "Living Curriculum" definition, plus formal professional development tracks tied to classical pedagogy (Socratic, Progymnasmata, etc.).
- For Element 3 (Curriculum): More explicit incorporation of Great Books and Great Conversation across core subjects; publish a clear Great Books reading list and integration plan across K–12.
- For Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal) and Element 6 (Parents & Community): Continue to strengthen public articulation of formation-over-information in all grades and expand offerings for parental formation to emphasize classical goals and shared culture.
- General: Consistently connect core classical elements (Trivium, Core Knowledge, memory work, singing/chanting in earlier grades) to measurable outcomes (assessments, performance, character indicators) and publish these linkages publicly.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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